

Case 1: The Ad That Didn't Match the Brand

Domain: Sales and Marketing | Decision Archetype: Positioning Strategy | Framework: STP + Positioning Map

Mumbai, a Tuesday morning.

Rhea Malhotra, CMO of NovaTel, was scrolling through her phone when her sister forwarded a WhatsApp message: "Since when did NovaTel become this fancy? Thought you guys were for students and small shopkeepers?"

Attached was NovaTel's new ad — sleek visuals, a Bollywood actor in a blazer, the tagline: "NovaTel. For Those Who Lead."

NovaTel had built its base over six years as the go-to network for tier-2 towns, college students, and small business owners — cheap recharges, simple plans, no frills. Last quarter, the leadership team decided the brand needed to "move up" to compete with premium players chasing urban professionals. They hired a new agency, repositioned the brand as aspirational, and rolled out the campaign nationally.

Three weeks in, the numbers were confusing. Urban sign-ups had barely moved. But in NovaTel's original strongholds — the small towns — recharge renewals had dropped 12%. Customer care was flooded with messages like Rhea's sister's: confusion, mild betrayal, jokes about NovaTel "getting too big for its boots."

Rhea called a meeting with the research team. They pulled together two simple pieces of data: a customer perception survey (asking existing users to rate NovaTel and three rivals on "Affordable to Premium" and "Basic to Trustworthy") and a quick breakdown of who was actually renewing plans versus dropping off.

The perception map was clear: NovaTel's original loyal base saw the brand as affordable and trustworthy — not premium, not aspirational. The new campaign hadn't shifted urban perception much yet, but it had already confused the core base.

Rhea had two weeks before the board reviewed campaign performance. She had to decide: push forward and give the repositioning more time, walk it back to the old identity, or find some middle ground that kept both audiences happy.

Exhibit 1 — Perception Map

Customers plotted NovaTel and 3 rivals on two axes (Affordable↔Premium, Basic↔Trustworthy). NovaTel sits firmly in the affordable-trustworthy quadrant; competitors are spread across premium quadrants.

Exhibit 2 — Renewal Data by City Tier

City Tier	Renewal Rate (Before Campaign)	Renewal Rate (After Campaign)
Tier 1 (Urban)	71%	73%
Tier 2/3 (Core base)	89%	77%

Discussion Questions

1. Should NovaTel continue the premium repositioning, or reverse it?
2. Can a brand serve both its loyal base and a new aspirational audience at the same time?
3. If you were Rhea, what would you tell the board in two weeks?